

BIOMASS ENERGY & AI

Reforestation in Mitsue — Ecology · Energy · Digital Infrastructure

v4.2 · 2026-08-20 · Rob Oudendijk

"The forest our ancestors planted — the power that sustains the village they built"

A 25-year initiative to revitalise the former Sugano Elementary School and the forest that surrounds it

What the Project Is

Transforms the **former Sugano Elementary School (Mitsue Taiken Koryukan)** (leading candidate site, final choice confirmed in Phase 1) and the aging cedar forest above it into a living model of rural self-sufficiency. Three elements work together:

- **Forest restoration** — Replacing aging sugi monoculture with native species. Thinnings yield biomass fuel; native broadleaf trees feed deer/boar/bear, reducing crop damage
- **Biomass CHP energy** — Sugi thinnings fuel a combined heat & power system (electricity + heat), complemented by solar and EV charging, with backup during outages
- **Sustainable AI data center** — Small, efficient digital facility in the former school or a disused factory, powered entirely by local energy — new infrastructure and jobs

These are not three separate ideas — each one makes the others possible.

The Problems This Project Solves

Challenge	How the Project Responds
Former school/factories vacant	Repurposed as data center & community anchor (site confirmed Phase 1)
Cedar monoculture, ecologically depleted	Systematic conversion to native mixed forest
Grid dependency, no local power	Biomass CHP from sugi thinnings as primary supply, solar/EV as complement
Shrinking population, no local jobs	Roughly doubling the local forestry workforce + data center/energy/maintenance roles
Blackouts, wildlife crop damage	On-site biomass power keeps key facilities running; restored forest keeps wildlife in the woods

Who Is Behind It

Rob Oudendijk — Dutch electrical engineer, resident of Mitsue since 2012, core hardware developer for [Safecast](#).

Advisors: Ray Ozzie (Blues) · San Poisson · Takuo Dome (Prof. Emeritus, Osaka University) · Evin Zoet / Yoshiko Zoet-Suzuki (Transom) · Henry Takata (biomass plant operations)

A dedicated **non-profit** is being established with local residents, village leadership, forestry professionals, and academic partners.

Benefits Arrive Well Before Year 25

Timeline	Milestone
Year 1	Site (school/unused factory) activated; international media visibility
Year 2	Landowners begin receiving cedar harvest income
Year 3–4	EV charging stations operational
Year 4–5	Data center operational; local jobs begin
Year 5–10	Data revenue reinvested into village and forest programmes
Year 25	Native forest established; model published worldwide

Financing — Seeking Seed Money

No funding is secured yet. The immediate need is **seed money** to move Phase 0/1 forward (feasibility studies, legal incorporation, early outreach). Once in place, the plan stacks complementary sources: 林野庁 forestry grants · METI/NEDO rural energy grants · village 2/3–3/4 renewable-energy subsidy · FIT/FIP · J-Credit · data center revenue · impact investment.

Current Status

The project is in **Phase 0** — community consultation, feasibility study, non-profit formation. No major commitments have been made. This is the moment to ask questions, raise concerns, and shape what comes next.

How to Get Involved

- **Residents & landowners** — Join the consultation process
- **Foresters & new residents** — Paid roles as the crew doubles (relocation support available)
- **Investors & philanthropists** — Phase 0 seed money
- **Professionals & researchers** — Feasibility input, technical review, collaboration

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"If it works here, it can work elsewhere."

*The BIOMASS ENERGY & AI project · Mitsue Village, Nara Prefecture, Japan
Contact: Rob Oudendijk · oudendijk.biz@gmail.com · 080-2260-5966*



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